

Friday, November 18, 2022

To: Janine Solberg, instructor of ENG 380

From: Amy Flynn, student

Re: Usability Testing Results

I designed my usability test for two main purposes: to see how users understood the table of contents and to see how users would read and understand some of the more complex modules. The three modules I thought could be the most potentially confusing for an audience were inserting captions, numbering pages, and inserting a table of contents. So, the three tasks I had for my two participants were editing a pre-written essay by captioning two images, making a table of contents out of the four sections of the essay, and numbering the pages of just the essay content. I figured just the process of completing the tasks would help me see whether or not the table of contents was set up well. The specific wording of the activities is included below, as well as in the testing documents also attached.

- **Activity 1:** Label the image on page 2 as “Figure I: Big Tech in the US” and the image on page 6 as “Figure II: Uber and Deliveroo are companies involved in the gig economy.”
- **Activity 2:** The professor has required the different sections of this essay (Big Tech, Data Collection, The Gig Economy, & Conclusion) to be outlined with page numbers on the first page of the document like this. Add something like this to the first page of your essay. *(Participants were then shown a mock table of contents... see test documents.)*
- **Activity 3:** Number the pages of only the written content of your essay.

Given that the intended audience for my manual is first-year college students, I chose to conduct my usability testing with freshmen. I am fortunate to be a teaching assistant in a small freshmen seminar, so finding two appropriate volunteers only took an email. The first participant was Saniya, a first-year economics student and the second participant was Brandon, a first year managerial student. I asked both of them before testing what their level of familiarity with Microsoft Word was; Saniya said 5 while Brandon said 1. I was pleasantly surprised that the two participants had only surface level understandings or less of Word because I think that is very indicative of the actual audience that may reach for my manual. I conducted my testing on Thursday, November 17th, in the library. I provided the participants with written and verbal instructions for the activities, as well as a printed and online PDF version of the manual so they could use whichever they preferred.

Both Saniya and Brandon did not correctly complete activity 1. This could have perhaps been because I used the word “label” as opposed to “caption,” as I had wrongly assumed on the testing documents that the two would be relatively synonymous. Saniya upon looking at the table of contents for a minute or so said she “couldn’t find anything about labeling,” and both she and Brandon ended up simply typing the text underneath the pictures. I am not too concerned about this because I think that the assignment details of a real essay would specifically use the word “caption” if that was required, so that level of confusion would not exist and did not actually

have to do with the manual. The table of contents activity was definitely the most difficult one for both of them and took the most time of the test. Both were able to make a blank page and navigate to the proper insertion steps, but neither originally realized they had to convert the existing section headers to Styles. Brandon even started just typing a table of contents at one point before giving up the task and saying, "That can't be what you want me to do." Saniya also pointed out to me that one of my callouts had an arrow in an ambiguous place that had tripped her up. This is a reflection of the manual, in that while it is clearly stated, I think I have to make the note that explains the nuances of Word's table of contents function much more eye-catching so readers cannot ignore/miss it. I had thought about making the Styles pane its own module, but I still think that a first-year essay writer would not use Styles for anything but a table of contents. Therefore I am standing by keeping that information in the table of contents module, though if you disagree with that please let me know. Regardless, I will be re-working that module with more informative screenshots and greater emphasis on crucial information. The third activity went very well, and neither had an issue inserting page numbers after their first page. This was very encouraging because I thought those were perhaps some of the most potentially confusing pages.

There are a few things that I would change if I were to do more tests. I think I would have perhaps only provided the specific pages of the module I was testing; since I had wanted to see how the table of contents was read and used, I gave them all of the pages but I don't think the table of contents was the issue. If anything, having excess pages may have just confused the participants from the activities and wasted time. I also now understand why it was so emphasized in class that readers don't actually want to read, especially with the table of contents activity. It was a little frustrating to watch both of them scan over the section that so specifically said you have to convert section headers to Styles multiple times and not register it. However, I understand that is also a design flaw on my part in that it should be much clearer on the page. Overall, I got very valuable feedback and I think I can extrapolate some of these specific issues to other parts of my manual that I did not test in these sessions.